

Mayhem Management

Enterprises have had them for ages, but there's a lot to be said for an office domain, even if you don't span a hundred acres

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I Imagine this: an employee finds a useful piece of free software on the Internet, installs it, and spreads the good word among his colleagues. Everyone installs it, and all goes well until the software vendor comes knocking at your door, asking you to cough up for the corporate license (the free version is only for home user)—and this is the first time you're even hearing about this program!

You've probably never even been close to such a situation, but if you're managing twenty or more workstations individually, you're inviting it. There's a simpler way to manage the PCs on your network than running around to each one of them—you need to set up a domain for your office.

What Is It?

The traditional LAN workgroup is a peer-to-peer (P2P) network—all computers are at the same level, where no one machine can dominate another, even if it's to apply a security patch. So every time there's a new security fix for Windows XP (and that's quite often), you have to either go to each PC and install it yourself, or hope that the user has seen the update notification and installed it himself—neither of which is a hassle-free proposition.

In a domain, one computer—the *Domain Controller* (DC)—is responsible for the network, and the users logged on to it. For instance, it maintains a central database of users, so when someone logs on to his machine, it's the domain controller that authenticates him and sets his security privileges. Once someone is authenti-

cated on the domain, he has seamless access to all the resources on the network that you want him to—all with a few clicks here and there.

Ingredients

To set up a Windows domain, you'll need Windows Server 2003—the Standard Edition works for most—at Rs 25,000, it comes with a 25-user license, with additional licenses at Rs 1,250 each. It will scale up as your company grows, and it even supports multiple domains should the need arise. For companies with 75 users or less, we recommend Windows Small Business Server (SBS) 2003—at around Rs 26,000 for five client licenses, it's a somewhat limited version of Server 2003, but comes bundled with Microsoft Exchange Server to manage your e-mail, and SharePoint Server for collaboration, both of which are very useful (and very expensive) products that have to otherwise be purchased separately. Before you invest in it, you will need to take a good look at the way your company is growing—SBS supports a maximum of 75 clients,

